

The Compass of Connection: 30 Prompts to Find Yourself in Others.

A Journaling Guide to Connection and Self-Discovery inspired by the Philosophies of Ubuntu and Utu. Written by Michelle Mashonganyika.

Introduction: The Ancient Map for Modern Living

We often navigate life like solitary travelers, carrying the weight of our choices, losses, and dreams as if we have to do it all by ourselves. However, the truth is simple: we were never meant to walk this road alone.

I created this guide to share some of the principles and grounded wisdom that carried me through my own toughest challenges. Much of this insight comes from my grandmothers—women who stood as steady pillars for themselves, their families, and their communities. I still draw on their lessons every day. May this guide invite you to pause, reconnect with what matters, and stand firm in your truth as you navigate a chaotic world.

Ubuntu, is a profound African philosophy rooted in the concept of shared humanity, often summarized by the maxim, "I am because we are." It asserts that an individual's existence and identity are inextricably linked to the community; we are not solitary beings, but rather, we become fully human through our interactions, compassion, and relationships with others. This worldview prioritizes collective well-being over individual gain, suggesting that true success and happiness are achieved only when the community thrives together in a spirit of mutual respect and interdependence.. " It is an African philosophy that reminds us that our humanity is inextricably bound up in the humanity of others. We do not find our way by separating ourselves; we find our way by understanding our connection to the whole.

Utu, a philosophy found in communities of people living in East Africa, defines the essence of "humanness" or moral goodness. While closely related *Ubuntu*, Utu places a profound emphasis on the internal quality of character—embodied by dignity, compassion, and justice—that distinguishes a person as truly human. Captured by the proverb *Mtu ni watu* ("A person is people"), it posits that one's humanity is not merely biological but is realized and validated through benevolent relationships with others. Ultimately, Utu serves as a moral compass, asserting that individual well-being is inseparable from the collective good and that a meaningful life is one dedicated to upholding the dignity of the entire community.

In my work as a Psychologist and Coach, I have found that the philosophies of Ubuntu and Utu are not just a nice social ideal; they can offer profound wisdom and practical tools for mental, emotional and spiritual clarity. When we view our problems through the lens of connection, the path forward often reveals itself.

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How to Use This Guide:

Think of this workbook as a menu. The prompts have been designed from the philosophy of Ubuntu and Utu. You do not need to consume it all at once. Look through the categories below and see which one resonates with your current season of life.

- **Wading In:** These are gentle prompts to help you reflect and stabilize.
- **Diving Deep:** These are challenging prompts for when you are ready to do the "heavy lifting" and explore the shadow or what is in your blind spot.

Grab a pen and paper, take a breath, and let us begin.

1. Identity & Belonging

Finding the "I" within the "We."

We often search for "who we are" in isolation. Ubuntu teaches us that our identity is a reflection of the relationships that hold us. These prompts will help you find yourself in your history and community.

Wading In (Gentle Reflection)

1. **The Village of You:** List five people (past or present) who have contributed a "brick" to the foundation of who you are today. What specific quality did each of them give you?
2. **The Circle of Safety:** When do you feel most "at home" in your skin? Is it around a specific person, in a specific place, or doing a specific activity? Describe that feeling of belonging.
3. **Ancestral Gifts:** What is one strength, talent, or physical trait you possess that reminds you of a parent or grandparent? How does it feel to carry that piece of them forward?
4. **Receiving Support:** Ubuntu relies on reciprocity; relationships that are mutually beneficial. Where in your life are you currently allowing yourself to be supported? If the answer is "nowhere," where could you let someone in?

Diving Deep (Shadow Work)

5. **The Cost of Fitting In:** Ubuntu is about belonging, not conforming. Where are you silencing your true voice just to keep the peace or maintain a connection? What is the cost of that silence?

6. **The Inherited Burden:** We inherit wisdom, but we also inherit wounds. What is a fear or belief you carry that actually belongs to your parents or ancestors, not to you? Is it time to lay it down?

7. **The Shadow of Independence:** In what ways do you use "hyper-independence" (doing it all yourself) as a shield to keep people from seeing your vulnerability?

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8. **Defining Your Place:** If you stripped away your job title and your role in the family (mother, provider, etc.), what value would you still bring to your community simply by being you?

2. Conflict & Repair

Restoring the Balance.

Ubuntu teaches that, conflict is not just two people fighting; it is seen as a tear in the web of connection that eventually affects everyone. Repair is not about winning or being right; it is about restoring the flow of the relationship.

Wading In (Gentle Reflection)

1. **Shared Humanity:** Think of someone you are currently experiencing frustration in your relationship. Write down three things you likely have in common (e.g., "we both want to be respected," "we are both tired"). How does seeing this shared ground shift your anger?
2. **The Third Story:** In any conflict, there is your story, their story, and the "Third Story"—the one an impartial observer would tell. Write the story of your conflict from the perspective of a wise, neutral elder.
3. **The Ripple Effect:** If this conflict could be resolved tomorrow, who else in your life (children, colleagues, friends) would benefit from the peace?
4. **Intent vs. Impact:** Can you identify a moment where your good intentions had a negative impact on someone else? How can you acknowledge their pain without defending your intent?

Diving Deep (Shadow Work)

5. **The Mirror:** What quality in this difficult person triggers you the most? Is a quality you possess but refuse to acknowledge in yourself?

6. **The Payoff:** We often hold onto grudges because they give us something (e.g., a feeling of moral superiority, protection from getting hurt again). What is the "payoff" you get from staying in this conflict?

7. **Radical Responsibility:** Without taking 100% of the blame, can you identify the 2% of the situation that you are responsible for? What would happen if you owned that 2% fully?

8. **The Unspoken:** What is the one thing you are afraid to say because you fear it will break the relationship forever? Is the relationship real if it cannot hold this truth?

3. Leadership & Impact

Guiding the Village.

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Whether you lead a company, a family, or a community project, Ubuntu and Utu can support you redefine and create your leadership. “A King is a King by the grace of the people” is a proverb from Southern African communities that practice Ubuntu that can guide your leadership, it can inspire you to lead more from stewardship, and rely less on dominance to produce the results you want to see in the world.

Wading In (Gentle Reflection)

1. **Lifting Others:** Who in your circle has a talent or light that the world has not seen yet? How can you use your influence to shine a spotlight on them this week?
2. **Listening as Leading:** Think of a recent conversation where you did more talking than listening. If you could redo it, what question would you ask to unlock the other person's wisdom?
3. **The Legacy of Presence:** People may forget what you said, but they remember how you made them feel. How do you want people to feel after they walk out of a room with you?
4. **Everyday Stewardship:** What is one small area of your life (your garden, your team's morale, your home) that you are tending to with great care right now?

Diving Deep (Shadow Work)

5. Service vs. Ego: Are you leading to empower others, or are you leading to validate your own worth? When you help someone, do you need this person to acknowledge it?

6. Hoarding Power: Where are you holding onto control because you do not trust the "village" to handle it? What would it look like to trust the collective intelligence of your team or family?

7. The Shadow of the Savior: Do you often jump in to "save" people from their own challenges? How might this actually be preventing them from finding their own strength?

8. The Ancestor Test: Imagine looking back at your current leadership style from three generations in the future. Would your great-grandchildren be proud of how you treated people to get results?

Conclusion: These prompts are just the beginning. The answers you have written down are coordinates—clues to help you find your way back to yourself and your community.

If you found yourself lingering on a question or sitting with a truth that feels overwhelming to hold alone, take a breath—this is where your transformation begins. Visit www.way-finding.co.ke to schedule your discovery call and discover which space best honors your growth.

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